FOUR EXPERTS · PLAIN-LANGUAGE SUMMARY · 1 NOV 2026

What the experts found

Four experts worked on your ideas separately: a designer of first-time experiences, a researcher on preludes, a documentary writer for Glenn's films, and a difficulty analyst who ran our simulated beginner, João, 1,440 times. Each was told to work out what you are really after before proposing anything.

The short version

1. **The fugue is the prize.** A player should hear a fugue whole only by playing it to the end. Everything else should protect that moment.
2. **Glenn's films work as scripts the game performs**, not recorded videos: short excerpts, flags on the notes, never the ending.
3. **The best first fugue is I/22, not I/1.** I/22 is slow and long-noted. In João's simulated runs, the two weakest beginner levels never finish I/1 at normal speed.
4. **Speed is what makes a fugue hard.** The hardest fugues have notes about a fifth of a second apart.
5. **The crowd could be fairer without becoming soft.** Forgive a wrong note, but not a missed one.
6. **Preludes need their own ways of playing.** The experts found six. They belong to a separate project.

1. What you're really after

The first-hour designer put it like this:

- **A fugue you open with your own hands.** The big moment is hearing it whole for the first time *because you are playing it.*
- **Learning that feels like being let in on a secret,** from someone who loves the music, not homework.
- **A guide, not a menu.** Twenty-four tiles ask a beginner to choose before they know what anything means.
- **An honest challenge.** If everyone gets through, winning means nothing.
- **A world that grows**: new pieces, new instruments, a reason to come back.

- **The fear:** a friend sits through lessons, fails a fugue and never returns.

2. How to welcome a new player

The designer weighed four ways of shaping a beginner's first two hours:

- **Thin the score.** Every fugue is open, but first in a "sketch" with only a few of your notes, as easy levels do in Guitar Hero. **Rejected**: you would hear the whole fugue before earning it.
- **Glenn's TV season.** Fifteen-minute episodes in Glenn's chosen order. **Right tone**, but it's a corridor: one hard episode blocks everything.
- **A map of keys.** Twenty-four houses around the circle of fifths. Lovely, but neighbouring keys are not in order of difficulty.
- **Your option 4.** Preludes teach, and each one opens the next prelude and a fugue. **The designer's pick**, with the prelude order following difficulty, not Bach's numbers.

You have since chosen something simpler: keep the tutorial and make Glenn its host, and give every fugue a LEARN film. Three of the designer's ideas still fit that plan:

- **Never give away the ending.** This is now a rule in Glenn's films.
- **Have Glenn suggest one next piece** each time you return, instead of leaving you facing 24 tiles.
- **A short "room" film for each instrument.** One or two minutes, shared by all pieces with that sound.

3. Glenn's films

- **The game plays them live from a script.** Translating means changing text only. The excerpts sound on your chosen instrument. A film is a small text file, and a test can check every bar it quotes.
- **About three minutes:** roughly two on the piece, one and a half on how to play it, never more than four. The how-to-play chapter is marked on the slider and has a jump button.
- **Rules that protect the piece:** at most four bars in a row, never the last part or the climax, and only a small share of the piece in total.
- **Background music:** if any, only soft held chords from bars already quoted. Never the piece itself.
- **Three short clips instead of one film** is a cheaper option: Glenn pops up for 30 seconds at the moment each one matters.
- **Busoni:** the game has his markings for the 48 fugues but not for the preludes. In prelude films Glenn's joke becomes Busoni's absence.

- **Quotations:** you've decided Glenn should look like Gould. One rule remains: his lines are the game's own wit, never invented quotations of the real man.

The I/1 film I built in the Lab bends two of the writer's rules. It quotes about a third of the piece (the writer suggests 30% at most), and its how-to-play chapter shows bars 8–10, which chapter 1 never played. Both are easy to tighten if you prefer.

4. Preludes: a separate project

Many preludes aren't made of separate voices, so "play one voice" often doesn't work. The researcher sorted Book I's preludes into four kinds:

- **Patterns** (1, 5, 6): one chord a bar, broken the same way.
- **Machines** (2, 3, 15, 21): both hands running faster than a thumb can follow.
- **Inventions** (about a dozen): the hands imitate each other.
- **Songs** (4, 8, 9, 10, 16, 22, 23, and the upper voices of 24): a melody over an accompaniment.

Six ways to play them:

1. **Outer voices.** Left thumb on the bass, right thumb on the top note. This is what you already liked in Prelude 1.
2. **Catch the layers.** Play a layer cleanly and it goes on playing by itself. You build the music up one layer at a time.
3. **Slow strands.** A broken chord is really five slow tunes. Pick one and follow it.
4. **Follow the motif.** Catch the theme each time it passes from one hand to the other. This is the core skill for fugues.
5. **Surf the line.** Slide your thumb along runs too fast to tap.
6. **The singer.** Play the melody, scored on smoothness and shape.

The researcher also mapped Prelude 1 bar by bar, from one bass note a bar up to the full figure by the end. One correction to your sketch: the top note falls on beats 2 and 4, because the bass is played again on beat 3. A separate demo page, with sound, shows four of these styles on Prelude 1's real notes. A new session on preludes is already queued as a suggestion for when you want it.

5. João's numbers

João is a simulated beginner at ten skill levels. Level 1 is sloppy: loose timing, with one note in three going the wrong way. Level 10 is solid. The analyst played every Book I fugue at every level, at normal speed and at SLOW.

HOW HARD	FUGUES (EASIEST FIRST)	WHO FINISHES
Gentle	I/22, I/8, I/14, then I/6, I/24	Almost everyone, even level 1–2
Middle	I/4, I/23, I/5, I/1, I/12, I/19	From about level 3–4
Hard	I/16, I/2, I/13, I/17, I/18, I/21	From about level 5–6
Hardest	I/11, I/9, I/20, I/3, I/15, I/7, I/10	Level 7–9

- **Speed decides it.** The easiest fugues move at about one note a second, with long notes. The hardest have notes about a fifth of a second apart.
- **Beginners lose Fugue I/1 in bars 8–12,** where quick pairs of notes and overlapping entries pile up. At SLOW, every level finishes it.
- **Grades:** D happens sometimes, in 44 of about 1,070 finished runs. E never happened: the crowd leaves before a run could finish under 60%.
- **Today's Prelude I/1 is only a timing exercise.** It asks for one tap every two seconds, and the height of your taps isn't checked. It does not prepare a player for Fugue I/1.

Fairer crowds, simulated on Fugue I/1

CROWD RULE	SKILL LEVELS THAT FINISH (OF 10)	LOW GRADES POSSIBLE
Today	8	No
8 bars of grace at the start	9	D
Forgive a wrong note, not a missed one	10	D and E
Bach plays your missed note (no points), plus grace	10	D and E
Punish clusters of mistakes harder	7	No

Forgiving wrong notes works because most beginner mistakes are wrong notes, not missed ones. Going silent still costs full price, so the crowd keeps its bite, and low grades finally mean something.

6. What this means for the Glenn plan

1. **Glenn should suggest I/22 as the first fugue,** then I/8 and I/14, with I/1 offered at SLOW.
2. **Each film's how-to-play chapter should aim at the bars where players actually fail,** as the I/1 pilot does with bars 8–12.

3. **The "forgive a wrong note" crowd** is a small change with a large effect. It's a separate decision for you.
4. **Preludes wait** for their own project, starting from the six styles and the demo page.

> ## Where the experts disagreed with you
>
> **Fugue I/1 as the first fugue.** The numbers favour I/22. You can keep I/1 first if its fame matters more to you, but offer it at SLOW from the start.
>
> **Prelude I/1 as preparation.** In its current form it teaches a steady pulse, not the quick small steps fugues demand.
>
> **Prelude I/1's top note on beat 3.** The data puts it on beats 2 and 4.